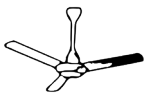
THE BATTLE PLANS



YSR CONGRESS PARTY

- Target the rival alliance by tweaking the narrative to one of whether the people want Jagan in (for another term) or out
- Paint it as a class battle between the have-nots, who benefit from welfare schemes, and the haves, who back rival parties and have allied to stop the schemes
- Get OBCs to back the welfare governance model
- Reach out to voters in a poll blitzkrieg in the final fortnight before the May 13 vote using his 700,000-strong army of activists

NATIONAL DEMOCRATIC ALLIANCE

- Field 'resourceful' candidates who can draw on their own clout besides that provided by the BJP-TDP-Jana Sena alliance
- Target YSRCP and Jagan for failing to bring all-round development to the state
- Organise joint rallies to emphasise the need for a smooth transfer of votes



CONGRESS-LEFT ALLIANCE

- Target the YSRCP through a campaign steered by charismatic state party president Y.S. Sharmila, CM Jagan's sister
- Hold out the promise of implementing a vibrant 'Nine Guarantees' programme

transfer of benefits (mostly online) have also endeared the YSRCP chief to the state's marginalised sections.

Naidu has struggled to find fault with Jagan on this, though he has ensured that the Election Commission barred the 266,000 GSWS volunteers from the election process. With Jagan assuring his "young army" that they will be reappointed "in the first file after re-election", many of them have now resigned and are officially working for the YSRCP. This is a setback for the TDP alliance as the volunteers have circumvented the EC fiat.

The TDP is targeting the ruling party on other governance aspects, though. "Remember, the YSRCP is a one-man show," says B.V. Muralidhar, head of the department of political science at Sri Venkateswara University, Tirupati. "Its influence has declined since 2019 owing to anti-incumbency. The NDA coalition has been targeting it on issues like corruption, the sand and land mafia, incidents of atrocities against SCs/STs, lack of capital investments and for reneging on its promises to government employees." Jagan's plan of having three capitals for the administration, legislature and judiciary at Visakhapatnam, Amaravati and Kurnool, respectively, has also come in for flak, and is still awaiting judicial clearance.

However, on the vexatious issue of getting special category status (SCS) for Andhra Pradesh after the 2014 reorganisation, the TDP and its NDA allies are silent. The BJP is against granting it, apprehensive that it'll raise similar claims in other parts of the country. The YSRCP is also avoiding the issue as it will need a working relationship with the BJP if each side finds itself in power post-polls in Andhra and New Delhi.

While the NDA is working on a common manifesto, the TDP has promised "a new vision for Andhra Pradesh with Super Six guarantees". Naidu's son and TDP national general secretary Nara Lokesh says it includes creating 2 million jobs for the youth and an unemployment allowance of Rs 3,000 a month until they secure one. "The Thalliki Vandanam scheme will provide Rs 15,000 a year to every schoolgoing child while farmers will get Rs 20,000 under the Annadata scheme," he promises.

But there are other challenges. Inter-party coordination is still an ask with some sections of the BJP opposing the alliance with the TDP. "Campaign coordination and transfer of votes among allies are serious issues for the NDA, besides the SCS. The same alliance was in play in 2014 but they had broken up in 2018 over the BJP vetoing the SCS," says E. Venkatesu of the department of political science at University of Hyderabad. "If there is no clarity on these issues, the NDA will come under enormous pressure."

Social commentator D. Subramanyam Reddy describes the election battle in Andhra "as a vote to decide whether people want pragmatic grassroots governance (Jagan) or political ad hoc administration (Naidu)". The latter, the longest serving chief minister of Andhra Pradesh (including the original and truncated versions), may not agree to the characterisation. In an emotional appeal to his Telugu *biddas*, Naidu has already announced that this will be his last election. Whether they heed his call remains to be seen. As for Jagan, his YSRCP is the team to beat this election. What is sure is that as the mercury rises, so will the acrimony on both sides. ■